

The current study aimed to examine the relationship between intellectual humility and apology quality, and whether a post-transgressional response also impacted apology quality. In accordance with our preliminary analysis, we did find a positive correlation between intellectual humility and apology quality. However, our primary analyses did not support our hypotheses. We found there was no significant effect of intellectual humility on apology quality. Furthermore, apology quality was unaffected by a victim's post-transgressional response. Finally, the interaction between intellectual humility and post-transgressional responses also did not affect apology quality. These findings do not undermine the strength of our study, which utilized an experimental design. This goes beyond the limitations of only using a correlational design.

Our study found a positive correlation between intellectual humility and apology quality. Ludwig et al., (2022) also found there to be a statistically significant relationship between intellectual humility and apology comprehensiveness. Combining these findings, because both experiments found a positive association, there is a strengthened likelihood that the two variables are in fact related. This consistency increases our confidence in the relationship between the variables. Additionally, these results confirm our belief that the vignettes used in both studies were temporarily influencing intellectual humility as intended.

Next, when looking at the main effect of intellectual humility on apology quality, our study aimed to heighten one's intellectual humility by having them imagine a scenario where they acted in accordance with the definition of intellectual humility. This manipulation of intellectual humility did not have a statistically significant effect on apology quality. The present results are inconsistent with Koetke et al.'s (2023) work, which deals with the effect of intellectual humility on investigative behavior. Their manipulation of intellectual humility, using the fallibility salience test, successfully increased participants' levels of intellectual humility. This suggests that our method of manipulation was faulty. Perhaps, using the fallibility salience test in our study would have led to statistically significant results for this main effect.

Additionally, we found there to be no statistically significant relationship between intellectual humility and post-transgressional response. In contrast, Koetke et al. (2024) found there to be a statistically significant relationship between intellectual humility (CIHS) and both positive and negative post-transgressional responses from the transgressor's perspective. Combining these findings, Koetke et al., conducted a more comprehensive statistical analysis while also controlling for factors such as the social desirability effect. Thus, the difference in results could be explained by the existence of confounding variables influencing our results, while being controlled in Koetke et al.

Finally, we delved into the interaction between intellectual humility and post-transgression response on apology quality. Participants may have over- or under-reacted compared to how they would have actually reacted in the specific scenario we had them imagine themselves in. This helps us understand why we did not find any significant relationships between intellectual humility and post-transgression response on apology quality.

When we had participants recall a time when they acted with intellectual humility, this may not have actually heightened their level of intellectual humility as much as we hoped. In turn, they could have completed the survey with their intellectual humility unheightened. This could explain why there were no significant findings for any of our hypotheses.

Both limitations can be addressed by conducting a future study in a lab environment, where increased internal validity would allow for better control of these variables. Creating a simulated environment where participants are not able to self-report but instead have their behaviors constantly monitored could produce more accurate results. Additionally, increasing intellectual humility by putting an individual in a “real” scenario would likely be more effective at influencing this variable than by having an individual just reflect. Lastly, including a pre-manipulation measure would have also given a baseline to ensure the intended effect of the reflection was achieved.

In future research, an experimental study with increased internal validity would produce interesting results. For example, many of the limitations of this study (social desirability, self-report, ect) could be controlled by having an in-lab experiment where participants were not able to think about their answers, and instead reacted in the moment. We hypothesize that creating a more impulsive environment would lead to a decrease in experimental intellectual humility and apology quality, possibly resulting in a clearer correlation between the two variables.

Additionally, looking at how demographic differences between the transgressor and the victim could produce interesting results. For example, does post-transgressional response and/or apology quality change when the victim and transgressor are of different sex, age, or race? We hypothesize that social psychology factors, such as social identity theory, may result in decreased intellectual humility and/or apology quality to members of different groups than within groups.

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